



Michael Kennedy

UX RESEARCH & DESIGN LEADER:

CROSS-FUNCTIONAL PROJECT DELIVERY & DATA-DRIVEN INSIGHTS

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UX Research and Design Leader with 14 years of experience building and running research practices, turning findings into decisions that change product direction, and designing experiences that achieve users' desired outcomes. Creative and thoughtful designer skilled in rapid prototyping, design systems, and design thinking facilitation. Senior researcher with leadership range and demonstrated readiness for team management, fluent across qualitative and quantitative methods, from field research, interviews, and usability testing to statistical analysis in R and SPSS, designing mixed methods approaches suited to the problem space. Builds custom, AI-enabled research infrastructure, rapid synthesis methodologies, and rapid prototyping workflows with an evolving AI/LLM toolset including Figma, keeping pace with product decision-making. Leads research and design independently and collaboratively, specializing in research operations within high-velocity Agile/Scrum environments and establishing practices that raise research's visibility and value across organizations. Delivers insights with executive visibility and direct impact, leading with optimism, confidence, and rigor that inspire teams toward excellence.

Professional Experience

UX Research Lead

Feb 2026 – May 2026

DCG Worldwide — Remote and On Location

- Owned the research strategy for a new paper billing process at a multi-service regional utility, covering screener design, a mixed-methods study plan, an AI capture process, and reporting format. The work traced what was driving billing-related call volume, repeat contacts, and escalations.
- Built a structured, AI-queryable research repository indexing 50 interviews in NotebookLM, enabling continued insight extraction for the client after the engagement ended. Clarified ambiguous statements in the audio in real time during sessions to strengthen the data feeding that capture process.
- Delivered findings across virtual and in-person testing, building rapport and maintaining neutrality with customers justifiably frustrated by significant billing errors, that reduced paper-bill comprehension call times and increased first-bill customer confidence despite a low-trust starting point.

Senior UX Researcher II

May 2024 – Dec 2025

SimSpace — Boston, MA (Remote)

- Built a new UX research practice for four product teams building a cyber range platform: a repository, personas, and standardized protocols that became their shared operating infrastructure.
- Designed customer feedback programs to shape and prioritize product roadmaps across four teams: an ongoing Design Partner Program, and the 2024 Customer Advisory Board, planned and prepared to open a new line of strategic customer input.
- Developed AI-enabled synthesis protocols using Claude, NotebookLM, and GPT that accelerated aggregation of interview and testing data into actionable findings.
- Validated every facet of a major milestone release through iterative testing to retain the company's top contracted DOD customer.

Lead UX Researcher

Oct 2023 – May 2024

RCG Global Services — Iselin, NJ (Remote)

- Led discovery research and multi-day design thinking workshops across five user groups (HR, Finance, Technical Staff, Product Management, and MEL) for a USAID-funded financial reporting platform supporting international development projects abroad, where reporting accuracy tied directly to congressional funding. Findings were reframed as "how might we" statements that directly shaped a platform redesign eliminating the pain points surfaced.
- Created a formal process for the working group's research intake, collaborative synthesis, and decision-making, and built reusable artifacts the design team continued using after the engagement ended.

Leadership & Management Development

Jan 2023 – Oct 2023

Nielsen Norman Group, Eager Labs — Watertown, MA (Remote)

- Completed a UX Certificate with specialty recognition in UX Management, concentrating coursework in Being a UX Leader, Workshop Facilitation, Research Operations, Design Systems, and Building Better Outcomes Between Product and UX, a deliberate focus on leadership and management capability.
- Completed Eager Labs' "Emerging Leaders" program upon executive referral, a five-session course for internal leaders being considered for people management, with a 360 feedback assessment and ongoing 1:1 coaching.

Senior UX Researcher

Oct 2021 – Jan 2023

SecurityScorecard Inc. — New York, NY (Remote)

- Drove 5–15% improvement in customer retention and conversion through end-to-end research on onboarding, pricing, and plan experiences with Growth product teams, shaping a persona-driven onboarding process the company shipped.
- Defined user archetypes for multi-jurisdictional security monitoring through extensive Jobs-to-be-Done and Jobs-Atlas research into regulatory and public-sector needs, informing a new tool the company delivered for public-sector monitoring.

Principal UX Researcher

Mar 2020 – Oct 2021

Veracode — Burlington, MA (Remote)

- Formalized a new UX Research practice as Veracode's first Principal Researcher, building research protocols, discovery frameworks, and design thinking capabilities from the ground up.
- Co-created a Developer Partner Program feeding discovery, concept testing, and usability testing with developer users, growing the participant base to scale research.
- Delivered 14 strategic research initiatives applying a Jobs-to-be-Done framework to drive product vision while mentoring researchers in research methodologies.

UX Designer / Researcher

Nov 2017 – Mar 2020

IBM Resilient & IBM Security — Cambridge, MA

- Led integrated UX design and research for IBM's first large-vendor incident response platform, Resilient, with experiences included in Cloud Pak for Security earning IBM "Leader" recognition from IDC and Forrester.
- Conducted participatory design research and rapid iterative testing, using structured artifacts (Sketch, Figma prototypes), Python-supported analysis for developer-centered interface design, and a formalized GitHub-based research workflow to inform product changes that enabled cybersecurity analysts to relate and reduce duplicate security incidents at scale.
- Formalized years of design thinking practice into IBM's official training, becoming a certified design thinking facilitator equipped to teach and mentor design thinkers.
- Designed a feature letting analysts cross-reference digital security incident artifacts directly, replacing a manual lookup process and cutting incident resolution time by roughly 10x.

Senior UX Researcher / UX Researcher

Sep 2012 – Nov 2017

Constant Contact — Waltham, MA

Later Endurance International, following a 2016 acquisition

- Pioneered a site-visit research program grounded in academic rigor, shifting company culture towards radically centering the needs and expertise of the small business owner.
- Planned and ran a company-wide customer panel discussion for the entire organization, surfacing customer themes and concerns that shaped empathy and roadmap direction.
- Led initiatives end to end and executed 20+ studies annually using the widest methodology toolkit of my career: card sorting, tree-testing, first-click testing, statistical preference testing, quantitative testing in R, R Studio, Jamovi, and SPSS with ANOVA and t-tests, and an advisory role on a conjoint analysis.
- Mentored research interns and rotation program members, formalizing research planning processes that supported organizational growth.
- Maintained and evolved the research practice independently following the company's acquisition by Endurance International, leading the next phase of field research and conducting persona-defining studies with a participatory field research team of product stakeholders to co-create a strategic journey map across business units.
- Contributed to building out a fixed in-person usability lab with a one-way mirror and multi-camera capture system, creating an immersive environment for stakeholder attendance and lasting impressions of real insights by showing the cause of observed issues on video.

Education

Master of Science (MS), Human Factors in Information Design

2011 – 2013

Bentley University, Waltham, MA

Bachelor of Arts (BA), Visual & Media Arts

2005 – 2009

Emerson College, Boston, MA

Certifications

UX Certificate: Specialty Recognition in UX Management – Nielsen Norman Group, June 2023

Professional Development

Designing, Running, and Analyzing Experiments (R, SPSS) – UC San Diego, The Design Lab, 2017 • Graphic Design Specialization – Cal. Institute of the Arts, 2017 • Enterprise Design Thinking – IBM Security, 2017 • Experience Mapping Workshop – Adaptive Path UXWeek, 2016 • Gamification (Kevin Werbach) – University of Pennsylvania, 2014

Author & Speaker

Co-author of "You Want Me to What? A Practical Guide to Diary Studies" and Co-Presenter at UXPA International Conference, 2014

Skills

Research Methods

User Interviews In-Depth Interviewing Survey Design Focus Groups Usability Testing A/B Testing Contextual Inquiry / Ethnographic Research / Field Research
Heuristic Evaluation Accessibility Testing (WCAG 2.1/Section 508) Concept Testing Card Sorting / Tree Testing RITE Methodology
Design Sprints Longitudinal / Diary Studies Competitive Analysis Information Architecture SUS / NPS Benchmarking
Participatory Design Service Design Journey Mapping / Experience Mapping Persona Development Jobs-to-be-Done (JTBD) Framework
Descriptive & Inferential Statistics (ANOVA, t-tests, Conjoint Analysis, Confidence Intervals/Adjusted Wald Method) Qualitative & Quantitative Research
Mixed-Methods Research

Design, Practice & Project Leadership

Research Operations & Practice Building Customer Feedback Program Design AI-Enabled Research & Data Workflows (Claude, NotebookLM)
Low / Medium / High-Fidelity Prototyping Design Systems Interaction Design Visual & Graphic Design Design Thinking Facilitation
End-to-End Project Ownership (Scoping, Timeline & Stakeholder Management) Agile/Scrum Environment Experience Cross-Functional Collaboration
Process Design & Documentation Executive & Senior Stakeholder Communication Coaching & Mentoring Product Discovery User-Centered Design
Presenting Findings & Recommendations Product Design Data & Analytics

Tools

UserTesting UserZoom UserLytics Maze Qualtrics SurveyMonkey Alchemer (Survizmo) Proven By Users Ethnio dscout Dovetail Great Question
Optimal Workshop Respondent UserInterviews Pendo Figma Sketch InVision Miro Mural IBM Carbon Design System GitHub R / R Studio Jamovi SPSS
Python Excel Claude NotebookLM